The city that rediscovered its commercial spirit

Following reunification, Saigon entered a difficult economic period. Private commerce faced restrictions, businesses struggled and the city's traditional trading networks had limited opportunities to expand. In 1986, Vietnam introduced economic reforms known as Doi Moi, meaning renovation. These gradually opened the economy to private enterprise, international trade and foreign investment.

Today, the city is Vietnam's principal commercial and financial centre, generating approximately a quarter of the country's national economic output according to commonly cited estimates. It is home to major Vietnamese corporations, international banks, technology companies, universities and an expanding service economy.

The contrast between old and new is everywhere. Traditional markets operate within sight of shopping malls. Family-run businesses stand beside international brands. A modest street-food stall may share a pavement with an expensive speciality coffee shop.

A metropolis on the move

Estimates suggest that approximately 9.5 to 9.8 million motorbikes operate in the city. For many households, owning two or more is perfectly normal. The motorbike is not simply a means of transportation. It is a family vehicle, a delivery service, a shopping trolley and sometimes an entire mobile business. Watching the traffic can initially seem overwhelming, but there is a certain rhythm to it. Vehicles move around one another in a continuous flow. Crossing the road requires a little confidence and a steady pace.

The city is also investing in alternatives. Its first metro line, connecting Ben Thanh with Suoi Tien, began operating in December 2024. It represents an important step towards a modern public transportation network.

Across the Saigon River, the Thu Thiem peninsula is being developed into a major financial and commercial district. New residential towers, hotels and office buildings are changing the skyline, while the historic centre retains much of its older character.

Rapid development brings challenges, including congestion, pollution, flooding and pressure on traditional neighborhoods. Saigon is trying to become a modern international metropolis without losing the qualities that make it distinctive.

Understanding Saigon

Southern Vietnamese cuisine reflects the region's tropical climate and agricultural abundance. Fresh herbs, vegetables, seafood and tropical fruits are everywhere. Dishes such as **Com Tam**, broken rice served with grilled pork, and **Banh Xeo**, a crispy savory pancake, are among the local favorites.

The old Saigon survives in its architecture, Chinese temples, traditional markets and family memories. The new Ho Chi Minh City rises in its glass towers, expanding neighborhoods, international businesses and ambitions for the future.

So perhaps, while we are here, it is worth finding a little pavement café, ordering a Vietnamese iced coffee and simply watching the world go by.



OH CHI MINH

A CITY THAT NEVER STANDS STILL

STORY NOT WRITTEN BY XAVIER BRUNELLE

There are cities that reveal themselves slowly, through their monuments, museums and carefully preserved streets. And then there is Saigon. A city that seems to introduce itself all at once. Officially renamed Ho Chi Minh City in 1976, one year after the end of the Vietnam War, it is still affectionately called Saigon by many Vietnamese, particularly when referring to the historic centre. Even the international airport retains the code SGN. Names, after all, can change more quickly than the memories attached to them.

Today, Ho Chi Minh City is Vietnam's largest urban centre and economic powerhouse. While Hanoi represents the country's political authority and centuries of northern history, Saigon has traditionally been associated with commerce, migration, ambition and opportunity.

A city born from the south

Long before Vietnamese settlers established themselves here, the region belonged to the wider cultural world of the Khmer, whose influence extended throughout much of what is now southern Vietnam and Cambodia. From the 17th century onward, Vietnamese migration southward gradually transformed the region. This movement, known as Nam Tien, or the March to the South, expanded Vietnamese political and cultural influence towards the Mekong Delta.

Saigon was officially established as an administrative centre in 1698, under Nguyen Huu Canh, an official of the Nguyen lords. The origin of its name remains debated. One popular explanation connects it to the kapok tree, which once grew abundantly in the region. Another suggests that it developed from an earlier Khmer place name. Either way, the name itself reflects the multicultural roots of southern Vietnam.

Trade helped the settlement grow. Vietnamese merchants and Chinese communities established commercial networks, while Cholon, meaning Big Market, developed to the west into an important Chinese trading district. For generations, Chinese families played a significant role in commerce, and their influence remains visible today in the markets, temples and family businesses of the city.

The French Pearl of the Far East

Following their military intervention in Vietnam in 1858 and the subsequent conquest of the southern territories, the French established Saigon as the administrative capital of their colony of Cochinchina.

They imagined a city reflecting French authority and colonial ambition. Wide boulevards were laid out, government buildings constructed, churches erected, and theaters and railway connections gradually transformed the landscape.

Saigon became known as the Pearl of the Far East, a prosperous colonial centre whose harbor connected the region to international markets. Rice, rubber, coffee and pepper were among its important exports. As we walk through District 1, much of that period remains visible. The Central Post Office, Notre-Dame Cathedral, the Opera House and the former Hotel de Ville, now the People's Committee building, reflect the architectural ambitions of colonial Saigon.

But behind the elegant façades was a more complicated society. The city was built through the labour of Vietnamese workers and craftsmen, while colonial administration maintained considerable economic and social inequality. The French left an architectural legacy, but also a society increasingly determined to control its own future.

Saigon, capital of the South

Following the division of Vietnam in 1954, Saigon became the capital of the Republic of Vietnam, commonly known as South Vietnam. Government offices, military headquarters, foreign embassies and international businesses filled the city. Its streets became familiar to journalists, diplomats and American servicemen. Hotels, cafés, restaurants and nightlife developed around an international population, giving Saigon a character quite different from that of Hanoi.

The former Presidential Palace, today known as the Independence Palace, remains one of the most important historical buildings in the city. On 30 April 1975, North Vietnamese tanks entered its grounds, marking the collapse of the South Vietnamese government and the end of the conflict. The country was subsequently reunified, and Saigon was officially renamed Ho Chi Minh City in 1976.

Cu Chi: the underground world protecting Saigon

About 100 miles northwest of central Saigon lies Cu Chi, a region whose geography made it particularly important during the conflict. Situated along the approaches to the Cambodian border, Cu Chi occupied a strategic position on the northwestern side of the city. It became an important operational area for Viet Cong forces, who used the surrounding countryside, villages and plantations as a base from which to move towards Saigon.

The tunnel network began developing during the First Indochina War against the French. Local families and resistance groups initially dug simple underground shelters. As the danger increased, they developed escape routes, connecting individual passages between houses, gardens and neighboring communities.

Between approximately 1948 and 1965, these separate passages gradually developed into an extensive interconnected system. Construction continued in different areas during the following years.The tunnels were dug entirely by hand, without modern machinery. Estimates of the total length vary, but the regional network extended for well over 100 miles. The engineering was ingenious. The system was organized into different levels. Shallower sections were used for daily activities, where there was better ventilation, while deeper and narrower passages were primarily intended for concealment and escape.

There were underground meeting rooms, storage spaces, kitchens, medical facilities and sleeping areas. Special cooking bunkers used chimneys designed to disperse smoke through several openings, making detection from above more difficult. Some bomb shelters featured curved ceilings, helping redirect the force of explosions through the surrounding soil rather than allowing the ceiling to collapse directly onto those inside. Concealed trapdoors separated sections of the network, while narrow passages and defensive obstacles made it extremely dangerous for enemy soldiers to advance.

American soldiers tasked with entering and searching these underground passages became known as Tunnel Rats. Their work was exceptionally dangerous, involving darkness, confined spaces, booby traps and the constant risk of encountering armed resistance. Military operations eventually included extensive bombing campaigns intended to destroy the tunnel systems and surrounding infrastructure. Yet the network demonstrated how local knowledge, geography and extraordinary determination could challenge a technologically superior military force. Even crawling through a short section gives us an appreciation of just how difficult life underground must have been.